

There is no greater physical representation of Cold War strife than the miles of deteriorated Berlin wall. The wall, which stood from 1961 to 1989, served as a structural reminder of the ideological differences between the Soviet Union and its previous allies in the West. The decade and a half preceding the construction of the wall was wrought with building tensions between the Eastern bloc and the Western powers as the Soviet Unions, United Kingdom, United States, and France grappled for power in post-war Germany. East German leadership encouraged by Soviet recommendations instilled a variety of tactics to keep the West cut-off from its territory in Berlin and East Germans in the East, including land blockades to the city and additional measures that would increase the difficulty of leaving East Berlin. Eventually, the German Democratic Republic (GDR) realized that only a physical wall could keep people in. Through the analysis of letters, speeches, phone calls, and meeting notes provided by the Wilson Center Berlin Wall Collection, we can examine the chronology of the Berlin wall's existence and the powers behind its construction and destruction.

The USSR was the most powerful ally to the GDR and other Eastern Bloc countries. Stalin lead with an iron fist from 1922 to 1952, punishing dissenters and opponents to his leadership and communist mission severely until his death on March 5, 1953. On April 30th, 1953, Spencer Barnes sent a dispatch to the U.S. Department of State regarding developments in the GDR after Stalin's death. Barnes notes the obedience of Ulbricht as he continued to implement the policies in the Socialist Unity Party in Germany as directed by the Kremlin, however less enthusiastically. The "decreased zonal tension" Barnes says the Soviets fostered with their actions after Stalin's death was a Soviet policy as opposed to a GDR one This may have seemed like a hopeful shift to progression in the GDR, however, Ulbricht was not keen to push progression and lighten tensions as the USSR may have wanted, but instead pull the exodus

of people leaving East Berlin back in. A month earlier, days after Stalin's death, instructions were sent to Soviet representatives to inform GDR leadership that their request for border guards and regulation of transport on the East and West Berlin border was not feasible for its threat to East-West relations, undermined the Soviet and GDR policy of supporting German reunification, a disturbance of city order, and "would evoke bitterness and dissatisfaction from Berliners with regard to the government of the GDR and the Soviet forces in Germany, which would be used by the three Western powers against the interests of the GDR and the USSR." The GDR's concern of East Berlin's flight to the west was not as crucial of a problem to the Soviet Union, at that point. Ulbricht's request, though denied, laid the foundation of the idea of the Berlin Wall. The Soviet response, on the other hand, demonstrates the necessity of amicable relations between the East and West towards the beginning of the cold war, both in Berlin and on the Global stage.

Much to Ulbricht's delight, Khrushchev in a 1958 address announced that the German Democratic Republic should be dealt with directly in regard to their problems and issued an ultimatum to the Western powers to demilitarize the city in the next 6 months or the USSR would transfer the control of routes into Berlin to the GDR. By giving more power and the routes to East Berlin, Ulbricht would finally be able to close off the West from the East. Though the next six months didn't end in a GDR peace treaty, failed negotiations in the following years pushed Khrushchev to allow increased border control. Ulbricht's earlier request in 1953 was limited to personnel and was not accepted by the Soviet Union, yet a decade later, the USSR was able to make these concessions with an even more permanent barrier. In a letter to Khrushchev on September 15, 1961, Ulbricht updated him on what had happened in the USSR and how the August 13th construction of the wall had been received in both the East and West "generally positive". This marked the genesis of the Berlin wall and nearly three decades of lost hope for

East and West German unification. Though there was opposition by the people of the West, those who held political power had their hands tied on what they could actually do about a wall that lay legally within the GDR border. Ulbricht added in his letter, “regarding the USA, it obviously will play the strong man by bare-faced demands and thinks it will gain a better negotiating position from this,” and the strong man they played. While Kennedy would have rather had a wall than a war, he made it clear that the U.S. was adamantly opposed to the wall. Ulbricht, in a separate letter on October 30, 1961, complains of western provocation. France had told its occupation forces to refuse to show identification to any members of the GDR. Likewise, the United States promised to fly in hundreds of US troops into West Berlin who would “drive around in the capital of the GDR without being checked.” These provocations of western powers directly contradicted Ulbricht’s claim of generally positive global acceptance a month earlier. In this way, the west implicitly denounced the authority of the GDR and the divisive tactics that threatened the freedom of Berlin.

While the West could not physically bring down the wall without causing political and military conflict, they could instigate action from the Soviet Union who had control over the GDR and the Eastern Bloc. It was Ulbricht who vied most for the wall, but ultimately the USSR as the leading socialist power would make final decisions regarding the foreign relations with the capitalistic west. It was Khrushchev, influenced by Ulbricht, that initially supported the wall, but the secession of Gorbachev as head of the Soviet Union opened doors for reform both domestically and internationally. Gorbachev’s 1985 institution of perestroika, glasnost, and other liberal reform signaled that the USSR could make strides towards democracy, meaning the end of the wall in its satellite state. For years the West criticized the wall, but the Gorbachev era was the time to turn up the heat, pressuring Gorbachev to prove his loyalty to his liberal policies of

openess. On June 12, 1987, the 40th anniversary of the announcement of the Marshall Plan, Ronald Reagan took to West Berlin to commemorate the event, giving a speech at the Berlin Wall. He reminisced on the Marshall Plan's effects and the present contrasting positions between the communist and democratic worlds. He also shared the U.S. plans of disarmament simultaneously sending a global message to Gorbachev that the U.S. was taking steps towards peace and the USSR should do the same. Again, western provocation ruffled the Soviet Union, challenging the validity of Gorbachev's new policies. Reagan's demand was simple: " Mr. Gorbachev, tear down this wall!" As powerful as it was, the wall did not meet its demise for another two years. The challenge was in place, but the failure of the Eastern Bloc and nonintervention of the Soviet Union during demonstrations in the bloc in 1988 and 1989 ultimately brought the wall to its end. It spoke to the diminishing power of the USSR and the people of East Berlin followed in the footsteps of other Eastern Bloc countries and demonstrated against the oppressive measures of the GDR and USSR. Then, Günter Schabowski's press conference on November 9, 1989, announced the opening of travel between the FRG and GDR "immediately, without delay". It explicitly detailed the opening of Berlin, pointing to the official reunification that would soon follow. The conference signified an end to 28 years of two Berlins, ushering in an era of reconstruction and healing for East Berlin. Though Schabowski's delivery was clumsy and his understanding of the new regulations was relatively limited, but Schabowski had told the East Berliners exactly what they needed to hear: they were now free.

From its construction to its demolition, the Berlin wall served as a dangerous physical and ideological barrier. Ulbricht's desire to keep western influence out and East Berlin citizens in led to the oppressive division of Berlin, in turn further dividing the east and west powers.

Ulbricht's determination to build the wall, however, was met with western determination to see to its end. The United States, France, and the United Kingdom worked towards reunification for the split Berlin, eventually pressuring the USSR to tear down the wall. Nearly three decades of separation reflected the Soviet Union's diplomatic failures with the west and when the wall crumbled, so did the USSR.

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